

Murder of Maltese journalist inspires media reform

By Kaya Equevilley



On the University of Malta's main campus a memorial hangs of investigative journalist and blogger, Daphne Caruana Galizia on April 7. Daphne Caruana Galizia was murdered in 2017. Photo by Olivia Scott.

The 2017 assassination of Daphne Caruana Galizia, a Maltese investigative reporter and blogger, left lasting impacts and sparked changes in the country's news media landscape.

Schools in Malta have implemented education to increase and support media literacy efforts. The EU ratified a law to protect journalists, activists, academics and other public watchdogs against abusive litigation throughout EU member states. Many journalists throughout Malta have committed to pursuing investigative journalism, even though fewer youth have expressed an interest in the profession.

"Journalism has changed a lot since Daphne was killed," said Times of Malta Editor-in-Chief Herman Grech.

"This was an event that changed the outlook of life," said Ġorġ Mallia, an author and cartoonist and head of the Department of Media and Communications at the University of Malta.

“[Her murder] was an attack on the freedom of expression and an attack on democracy,” said Ġorġ Mallia.

“The assassination was done to send a message, to try and silence people seeking truth, but I think it made people fight harder for truth,” said Megan Mallia, the niece of Caruana Galizia, but no relation to Ġorġ Mallia.

Megan Mallia is a research support officer at University of Malta, and leads media literacy efforts in Malta.

It is widely known that Caruana Galizia was honest and critical of those abusing power in order to uncover the truth. She was a prominent and controversial investigative journalist and blogger who was assassinated for getting too close to the truth while working on an investigative story.

“She was killed because she was close to exposing the corruption,” said Ġorġ Mallia.

Before she was killed, Caruana Galizia received numerous death threats which she filed with the local police department, according to local media outlets.

The family of Caruana Galizia said that she faced other acts of violence leading up to her death.

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Malta is a sovereign state in Southern Europe, with a population of 545,000 in 2025, according to the World Population Review.

While being one of the smallest countries in the world, Malta has the second worst World Press Freedom Index rank in the EU. Worldwide, their rank is 73 out of 180. In previous years Malta has ranked lower; however, the change in position has more to do with a decline in other countries than the improvement of Malta’s journalistic landscape, according to The Shift News.

The Shift News is an online news portal in Malta with the aim of defending freedom of the press

“I don’t really follow the media outlets in Malta if I can help it because I think they are all corrupted,” said Maria Talio.

Talio was born and raised in Malta and has lived in various parts of the country.

“I heard about the death of the journalist, and you could see and feel it throughout the country but I couldn’t tell you what changed, just that there was mourning,” Talio said.

Megan Mallia said that Caruana Galizia’s legacy has inspired others to find the truth and to share it. She said there are many challenges in the field of journalism, including misinformation, lawsuits, political scrutiny, public scrutiny, and copyright allegations.

“Misinformation is one of the biggest damages to the relationship [between the news source and the reader],” said Bertrand Borg, the online editor for the Times of Malta.

Despite the challenges journalists face, many see solutions too. These include adapting to evolving technological advancements, being transparent with readers, and educating the community about proper journalism and journalistic practices.

“It’s about change, change will just kill you,” said Grech.